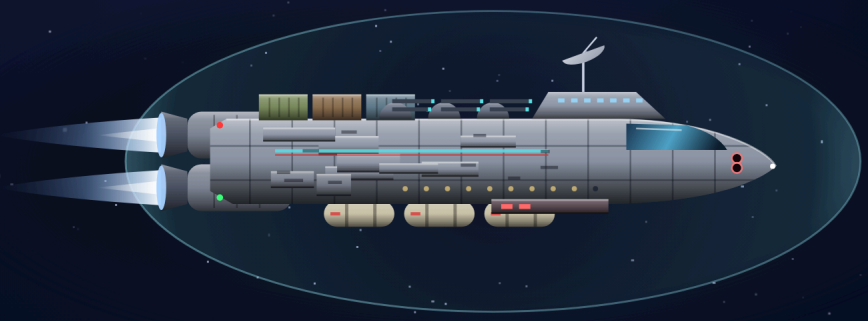
# STARFORGE

Version 0.91.1 · Beta

Chart an endless galaxy and meet its inhabitants. Discover what the Vael left behind.

## CAPTAIN'S MANUAL



*"Being a captain is a dangerous job in an unforgiving universe. Being a careless one just makes it somebody else's problem. Usually the first officer's."*

# Before you launch

**STARFORGE IS IN BETA**

This game is still in active development, and things can change quickly: new features, story chapters, balance changes and fixes arrive often, sometimes several in a day. Update regularly so you're always playing the latest version. Your saved game carries over when you update. If something looks wrong, it may already be fixed in a newer version.

> *"Being a captain is a dangerous job in an unforgiving universe. Being a careless one just makes it somebody else's problem. Usually the first officer's."*
>
> WORDS TO FLY BY

## PLAYING AND UPDATING

- Play in any modern web browser at bugabooman-lgtm.github.io/starforge.
- **Get the latest version:** Starforge.html always opens the newest release. Save it to keep a copy (see *Playing offline* below).
- **Get the latest manual:** Starforge-Manual.pdf is always the newest edition of this manual.
- To check for a new version, choose **Saves, Backups & Updates** on the title screen (or go to the Log tab) and press **Check for update**.
- Your game saves automatically in your browser. Make a backup before clearing your browser's data, or keep a backup file up to date (see *Saving* near the end of this manual).
- Found a bug, or have an idea? Write to GadgetsAndGizmotos@gmail.com.

## PLAYING OFFLINE

The whole game is a single file, so once it's saved it runs without an internet connection.

1. Open the game at bugabooman-lgtm.github.io/starforge.
2. On the title screen choose **Saves, Backups & Updates**, then **Download for offline play**. Your current game comes along inside the file.
3. Keep the downloaded **Starforge.html** anywhere on your computer and open it to play.

You can also save Starforge.html straight from your browser with Ctrl+S (Cmd+S on a Mac).

- **Saves stay with where you play.** Your browser keeps the offline file's saves separate from the website's. To move a game between them, use **Export** and **Import**, or **Load a backup file**, under *Saves, Backups & Updates*.
- **Updating an offline copy:** when you're online, **Check for update** still works. If a newer version is out, **Download** saves the new file with your game already inside it. Replace your old file with it.
- Offline, the game uses your computer's own fonts, so text looks slightly different. Offline play works best on a computer; phones make saving web pages awkward.

### IN THIS MANUAL


About Starforge
Welcome
Known Species
The Vael
Ship & Crew
Spaceport
Colonies
Exploring
Encounters
Saving
Controls


## About Starforge

Starforge is an open-world space exploration game: part survey mission, part trading run, part first-contact story. You command a small starship sent out from a lone starbase to chart a galaxy that keeps growing the farther you fly.

### THE INSPIRATION

In 1986 a game called *Starflight* put players in command of a starship with a hand-picked crew, a universe of hundreds of worlds to land on, aliens to talk to (or run from), and an ancient mystery hidden under all of it. It had one starbase, a fixed map, and a sense of wonder that stuck with a lot of people for a very long time.

Starforge started from a simple question: what if that universe never ended? What if the map kept expanding, if you could build new outposts and starbases as you pushed outward, and if the aliens had their own politics, wars and opinions about you? The goal was never to copy Starflight, but to chase the same feeling: of setting out into the dark not knowing what you'll find.

### HOW IT WAS MADE

Starforge was designed one idea at a time and built in conversation with Claude, an AI from Anthropic. It began as a galaxy builder for generating star systems, then grew a ship and crew, colonies, alien species and their territories, a walkable spaceport, planetary landings with a rover, wildlife, real-time ship combat, distress calls, lost Vael technology, and a story that runs through all of it. Each version added or refined something the designer wanted to see next. It runs entirely in a web browser as a single file.

### THE STORY SO FAR

Long before humans reached the stars, a species called the Vael spread across this part of the galaxy, and then vanished. Their ruins are everywhere, marked with the same glyph: a circle crossed by three lines. Nobody knows what happened to them.

You are a new captain with a modest ship, a small crew, and a home starbase that pays for every new world you survey. Out there are species who will welcome you, species who will tax you, and species who

will hunt you. And somewhere among the ruins is the beginning of a trail the Vael left behind, for whoever was curious enough to follow it.

## Welcome

### WELCOME ABOARD, CAPTAIN

You command a survey ship based at your home starbase. Your job is simple to say and hard to finish: go out, find worlds, and make a living doing it.

- **Explore.** Jump between stars, scan each system, fly to its planets and scan them from orbit.
- **Earn.** Survey data sells when you dock. Minerals you mine, relics you dig up and wildlife you capture all sell at the starbase too.
- **Expand.** Recommend habitable worlds to the Colony Office, build fuel depots, and push the frontier outward. The galaxy grows as you reach its edge.
- **Meet the neighbors.** Alien species have their own space, attitudes and rivalries. How you treat them decides how they treat you.
- **Stay alive.** Fuel, hull and crew are your lifelines. Run low on any of them far from home and you'll be calling for help.

The **title screen** lets you choose a mode: **Captain**, to play, or **Builder**, to create and edit galaxies. You can switch modes any time at the top left, and the **Title** link under the Starforge name takes you back to the title screen.

# Known Species

### SPECIES OF KNOWN SPACE

Six species are known to share this region of the galaxy. More are said to live past the frontier. Each species has its own territory. You'll see it on the map once you've met them. Their attitude toward you ranges from Friendly through Neutral and Wary to Hostile, and it changes with how you treat them.

| Species | What travelers say |
|---|---|
| **Lumari Concord** | Gentle plant-folk who fly seed-shaped living ships covered in slow-moving leaves. Welcoming to the curious, and among the best scientists and healers you can hire. |
| **Ossari Exchange** | Many-voiced traders in gaudy merchant barges strung with lights. Everything has a price, and they remember a good partner. They make superb communications officers. |
| **Kesh Swarm** | Insect-like beings whose ships fly in perfect formation, like a single animal. Watchful, terse and hard to read. Natural-born pilots. |
| **Vorrn Clans** | Heavy-world clans in slab-sided warships with armor welded on in layers. They charge tolls on their lanes, but respect those who earn it. Unmatched engineers. |
| **Skarr Dominion** | Raiders in black, barbed ships with weapon ports glowing red. They see most travelers as prey. Avoid them, or come armed. |
| **Thexx Hive** | Pulsing organic hulks that seem to swallow starlight. They do not talk. Nobody who has met them wants to again. |

Each species also has a few **colonies** in its own space. And travelers in cantinas tell stories of species beyond the frontier that no chart shows. Some of those stories may even be true.

Hailing, trading fairly and answering distress calls improve relations. Firing on a species, scanning them without asking, or flying armed through their space does the opposite. Species can also be at war with each other.

# The Vael

### THE ONES WHO CAME FIRST

Long before any of today's people reached the stars, the **Vael** spread through this part of the galaxy. Then they were gone. No one knows where they went or why.

What they left behind is everywhere, if you know how to look: ruins on dozens of worlds, old machinery that still hums, and one glyph carved into all of it: **a circle crossed by three lines**.

- **Ruins** show up when you scan a planet. Land and drive your rover to them to dig up relics, which sell well at starbases.
- Now and then, ruins, lounge spacers and alien envoys turn up **fragments of the Vael story**. They're collected in your **Codex** tab, and each one may point toward the next.
- Spacers swap rumors about Vael machinery that still works, if you can find all the pieces.

Whether the trail leads anywhere is up to you to discover.

## Ship & Crew

### YOUR SHIP

- **Fuel** powers every jump, landing and shield. Range depends on your engines and your navigator. Watch your tanks. You can buy fuel at starbases, skim it from gas giants, store it in fuel depots you build, or sometimes buy it from friendly aliens.
- **Hull** is your ship's health. Repair it at a starbase, or patch it in space using metal you've mined.
- **Shields** absorb damage until they're worn down, then recharge after each encounter. They only work while raised, and they burn fuel while up.
- **Weapons** (lasers and torpedoes) must be armed before they'll fire.
- **Upgrades** are sold at the shipyard: engines, fuel tanks, cargo pods, armor, shields, sensors, lasers and torpedo launchers. Each has five levels.

### YOUR CREW

- Every crew member has seven skills (Science, Navigation, Engineering, Communications, Medicine, Weapons and Charisma) and works one station. Their skill at that station grows with use, up to their species' limit.
- You **name your captain** when a new game begins.
- The **Captain** leads, and their Charisma affects trades and first impressions. The **First Officer** can hold a second post, and so can the Captain.
- **Every station matters.** Nobody covers an empty one. Without a science officer you can't scan, without a communications officer you can't hail, without a weapons officer you can't fire (shields still work), and without a doctor nobody heals. To jump at all you need a captain, a navigator and an engineer. Reassign stations any time on the Crew tab.
- Crew have **hit points**. Injured crew work less well. A doctor heals a little on every jump, or can treat someone directly from the Crew tab. Without a doctor the badly hurt get worse, and crew can die.
- If the captain falls, the First Officer takes command. If both are lost, the crew member with the most charisma steps up.
- Train skills and hit points at the starbase's Personnel office, and hire new crew there.
- **Crew quarters** and a **med bay**, bought at the shipyard, help everyone heal and learn faster, and can save a life.

# Spaceport

### YOUR STARBASE SPACEPORT

Dock at a starbase, then choose **Enter spaceport** to walk around. Walk left and right with A/D or the arrow keys, and press W, Up, Z or , at a doorway to go inside. Here's what you'll find:

| Place | What it's for |
|---|---|
| **Shipyard** | Buy ship and rover upgrades and load torpedoes. Hover over an upgrade to preview it on your ship. You can also rename your ship here, fit crew quarters and a med bay, and change your ship's look: hull designs, engine glows, paint schemes, and your ship's name painted on the hull. Looks never change how the ship performs. The shipyard also sells better **space suits**, which carry more air. |
| **Trade Depot** | Three counters: *Ship* (refuel, repair, medical bay, insurance), *Sell* (minerals, relics and wildlife specimens) and *Buy* (minerals). |
| **Personnel** | Assign stations, train any skill or hit points, and hire new crew from the *For hire* list. |
| **Lounge** | Buy a drink and talk. Spacers trade rumors and star charts, alien envoys share news from their own species, and your own crew sometimes pick up new skills over a good conversation. The bartender also sells star charts, tips and other information. |
| **Operations** | Station news, alien relations, and *starbase improvements* you can pay for: a bigger shipyard, a refinery, or a bigger lounge. Each one helps only at that starbase. |
| **Observation deck** | A window onto the docking bay, where you can see your ship as she looks today. |
| **Hall of Captains** | Only at your home starbase. A record of captains who have fallen in service, including any of your own. |

Starbase services are also on the **Starbase** tab while you're docked, if you'd rather skip the walk.

# Colonies

### VISITING COLONIES

Colonies are towns on planets, not starbases. Fly to the planet, move into orbit, and choose **Visit colony** (1 fuel for the shuttle). You walk the colony's street the same way you walk the spaceport.

### ALIEN COLONIES

- Each species keeps a few colonies in its own space. You'll see them once you've scanned the planet, or when someone tells you where one is.
- **Friendly** and **Neutral** species let you land for free. **Wary** ones charge a landing fee. **Hostile** ones order you away.

- Rovers aren't allowed on alien colony worlds. You visit as a guest.

| Place | What it's for |
|---|---|
| **Trade post** | Buy fuel and local minerals. Sell your cargo, relics and specimens. Goods the colony wants are marked *Wanted* and pay much more than a starbase. Some species sell rare ship parts here. |
| **Colony hall** | Talk to an official. You'll learn where their homeworld is, how they feel about you, and what they pay extra for. Officials will also sell star charts, tips and news of other species. |
| **Cantina** | Drinks, dice and gossip, like the Lounge, but with local regulars. Strangers drift through cantinas too, and some of them offer their services. Alien cantinas also keep an old slot machine in the corner. Keep an eye on your credits. |

### YOUR OWN COLONIES

Worlds you recommend become colonies of their own. Visit them to buy fuel from their refinery, sell them metal to build with, check on their progress at the colony office (where you can also fund them, so they grow faster), and share a drink in the mess hall or tavern.

### THE OLD COLONY

Your home system also has a colony of its own: the oldest human settlement in this part of space, here long before the starbase. It works like your colonies, and it has a few things you won't find anywhere else. It's worth a visit.

## Exploring

### GETTING AROUND

1. **Pick a star** on the map and press **Jump**. If you don't have enough fuel you can jump anyway, but you'll drop out in deep space and need the radio.
2. **Scan the system** on arrival to see its planets and their orbits.
3. **Fly to a planet**, move into orbit, and **scan it** to learn its atmosphere, minerals, life and habitability.
4. **Land** (costs fuel) and drive your rover. Mine deposits, explore ruins, and stun and load animals for study. Drive back to the lander to unload.

Your captain can leave the rover on any planet with the **Disembark** button, which tells you roughly how many seconds of air the suit holds there. A few places can only be reached on foot. Air refills back in the rover and inside the lander's circle. You can only lift off once the rover is back inside the lander's circle.

If the rover runs out of power or is wrecked far from the lander, your captain has to abandon it and walk back in a space suit before the air runs out. The lander recovers the empty rover when you lift off, but its cargo is lost.

### MAKING A LIVING

- **Survey data** from scans sells automatically when you dock.

- **Colonies:** recommend worlds with good habitability to the Colony Office from orbit. Worlds that already have an alien colony are off limits. Good picks pay a bonus. Poor ones get you fined.
- **Fuel depots:** build one in orbit around any scanned planet to make fuel over time. Depots in unfriendly space may come under attack.
- **Radio:** if you're stranded, call for a fuel delivery or a tow. It's expensive, but it beats drifting.
- **Breakdowns:** long jumps, a damaged hull and time since your last starbase visit all raise the odds of the jump drive failing mid-jump. Your engineer can repair it in a few days, or you can radio for a tow. Docking at a starbase services the ship. Rovers can break down too.
- **Crew mistakes:** less experienced officers fumble now and then. A science officer may need to rerun a scan or may get unreadable mineral data, a comms officer may lose a hail or garble an answer, and a navigator may misjump, dropping you somewhere near where you started instead of where you were going. The better the officer, the rarer it gets. A fully trained officer never slips.
- **Stardate:** today's date is shown just above the map coordinates.
- **Rumors & Leads** (in the Log tab) collects tips from travelers. Place names and coordinates are clickable and take you to the map.

## Encounters

### MEETING OTHER SHIPS

When you meet a ship, the game switches to the **tactical screen**: your ship, theirs, and a comms panel on the right.

- **Hail** to talk. Friendly hails improve relations and can turn up rumors.
- **Ask questions** once you've hailed: who they are, where they're from, what they trade, any news, how they get on with their neighbors, and what dangers are about. Wary species may refuse to answer, and push too hard and they'll close the channel.
- **Wanted goods:** every species pays extra for certain minerals, and some for relics or live wildlife. Ask what they trade, or visit one of their colonies, to find out. It's noted in your Known species list.
- **Request video** to see who you're talking to. Either side can refuse.
- **Trade** for fuel, minerals and relics. Your captain's Charisma gets better prices.
- **Scan** a ship to see its weapons, shields, cargo and fuel. Better sensors and a better science officer show more. They always notice the scan.
- **Tolls:** some species charge passage. Pay, refuse, or talk your way out.
- **Fight** if you must. Arm weapons and raise shields first. Range matters: the closer you are, the more you hit, and each weapon has a maximum range. You can target any ship on screen.
- **Surrender:** a badly beaten ship may give up. Board it and take its cargo and the ship itself, let it go (they'll remember the mercy), or finish it (everyone will remember that, too).

- **Towing a prize:** a captured ship sells at your starbase when you dock. Towing it burns about a third more fuel per jump. You can only tow one ship at a time. Board another, and your crew strips it for parts instead.
- **Wrecks** can be scavenged after a fight for salvage, cargo and fuel.
- **Raiders** haunt the edges of known space. Not every one of them wants a fight. Some just want to be paid.
- **Distress calls** come in while you travel. Answer them before you next dock, and you may make a friend.

Whether your weapons are armed and your shields are up changes how other ships react to you.

## Saving

### SAVING YOUR GAME

- Your game **saves automatically** in your browser as you play.
- **Backups:** the game keeps a few snapshots in the browser (every 10 game days, and before any import, restore or new galaxy). You can restore one from the Log tab.
- **Automatic backup:** clearing your browser's data erases its saves, so the game also keeps a copy somewhere safer. Choose a backup file once and it's kept up to date (Chrome and Edge), or a backup file downloads every 10 game days (other browsers).
- **Export** gives you your whole game as text to keep anywhere. **Import** or **Load a backup file** brings it back, in any browser.
- All of these are in the **Log** tab, and under **Saves, Backups & Updates** on the title screen, which also checks for a newer version of the game.

# Controls

## CONTROLS

| Where | Key | Action |
|---|---|---|
| Anywhere (Captain) | 1 | Raise or lower shields |
| | 2 | Arm weapons / set to safe |
| | 3 | Arm or safe special weapons, once fitted |
| Tactical screen | W A S D or arrow keys | Move |
| | Click empty space | Fly there |
| | Click a ship / Tab | Select a target / next target |
| | Z or , | Fire lasers |
| | X or . | Fire a torpedo |
| | C or / | Fire special weapons, once fitted |
| Planet surface | W A S D or arrow keys | Drive the rover |
| | Z or , | Mine, explore ruins, load animals |
| | X or . | Fire the stunner |
| | C or / | Fire a lethal shot |
| On foot | Disembark button | Step out of the rover |
| | W A S D, arrow keys or click | Walk |
| | Z or , | Climb back into the rover, board the lander, or work on what's in front of you |
| Spaceport | A / D or left / right arrows | Walk |
| | W, Up, Z or , | Go through a doorway |
| | Esc | Leave a room / the spaceport |
| Star map | Mouse wheel or pinch | Zoom |
| | Drag | Pan |